AUWA Website Specification — auwa.life

Created: April 2026. The specification for the auwa.life website — the brand's home and editorial hub. Load when building the website, planning content, or working on site structure.

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1. Purpose & Positioning

The auwa.life website is the front door to the AUWA brand. It establishes AUWA as a Japanese lifestyle brand rooted in philosophical awareness before the app, store, or book exist as products. The website is the first thing anyone encounters — it needs to communicate the world, not just announce a product.

What it IS: A Kinfolk-inspired editorial destination. Atmospheric, contemplative, photography-led, with journal articles as the heartbeat. A place you visit to feel something, read something beautiful, and understand what AUWA is about.

What it is NOT: A product launch page. A teaser page with an email form. A feature list. A marketing funnel. It's a brand world — the kind of site you'd bookmark and return to.

Structural references:

- **Kinfolk** (kinfolk.com) — The gold standard. Serif typography, generous whitespace, atmospheric photography, editorial authority. The grid layout of articles creates a magazine-like feel that rewards browsing.
- **Cereal** (readcereal.com) — Minimal, travel-focused, serif-heavy. Beautiful article layouts with photography that breathes.
- **Monocle** (monocle.com) — Editorial worldview extended across products, retail, and media. Clean, confident, opinionated.
- **It's Nice That** (itsnicethat.com) — Design culture editorial. Clean grid, strong typography, content-led.
- **Mubi** (mubi.com) — Dark, cinematic, serif display type. Proves dark-mode editorial can feel premium and inviting.
- **Hoshinoya** (hoshinoya.com) — Japanese luxury hospitality. Atmospheric, slow, immersive. The photography integration and pacing.
- **Aesop** (aesop.com) — Restraint as luxury. Serif type, dark palette, every detail considered.

Additional references to study:

- **The Kinfolk Table** layout style — how Kinfolk handles food/culture/travel photography within article pages
- **Apartamento** (apartamentomagazine.com) — Raw, intimate editorial photography
- **Analogue Life** (analoguelife.com) — Japanese craft curation, beautiful product storytelling
- **Snow Peak** (snowpeak.com) — How a Japanese brand presents philosophy alongside products

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2. Site Architecture

All sections live under **auwa.life** with subpaths. auwalife.com mirrors for the Japan market.

```
auwa.life/                  → Home (editorial hub + brand introduction)
auwa.life/journal           → Journal index (all articles)
auwa.life/journal/[slug]    → Individual article
auwa.life/app               → Kokoro Mirror introduction (pre-launch: coming soon with email capture)
auwa.life/store             → Store introduction (pre-launch: coming soon with craftsman preview)
auwa.life/book              → The AUWA story universe (pre-launch: introduction + email capture)
auwa.life/about             → Tom & Rieko, the philosophy, the origin
auwa.life/newsletter        → Email signup (also embedded across other pages)
```

Information Architecture

Home is the editorial hub — not a static landing page but a living, updating page anchored by journal content. Think Kinfolk's homepage: a hero article, a curated grid of recent pieces, and subtle navigation into the four pillars.

Journal is the SEO engine and the content heartbeat. Long-form articles, craftsman profiles, seasonal essays, Japan travel stories. This is where brand authority accumulates and where organic search traffic lands.

App, Store, Book pages are initially lightweight — atmospheric introductions that establish what's coming, with email capture. They become full sections as each pillar launches.

About tells the story of Tom and Rieko, the philosophy of Yaoyorozu no Kami, and the origin of AUWA. Written in the brand voice: quiet, precise, present.

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3. Page Layouts

Home Page

The homepage should feel like opening a beautiful magazine, not landing on a product page.

Structure (top to bottom):

1. **Header** — AUWA wordmark (Cormorant Light, tracked) left-aligned. Navigation right: Journal, App, Store, Book, About. Instrument Sans, small caps, tracked. Dark background (void). Minimal, fixed on scroll.

2. **Hero** — Full-width atmospheric image or the latest journal article as a hero card. Large Cormorant headline, one line of subtext, atmospheric photography behind. Slow, subtle parallax or gentle fade-in on load. No CTA button in the hero — the content IS the invitation.

3. **Brand statement** — A single line of philosophical text. Centred, Cormorant, generous whitespace above and below. Something like: "Japanese philosophical awareness applied to modern life." This is the only "explanation" on the page. Let it breathe.

4. **Journal grid** — 3-6 recent articles in a Kinfolk-style grid. Mix of card sizes (one large, two medium, or asymmetric layout). Each card: atmospheric photography, Cormorant headline, one-line description, category tag. Dark backgrounds, warm photography.

5. **The Four Doors** — A quiet section introducing the four pillars. Not a feature grid — four atmospheric panels (image + short text) that invite exploration. App, Store, Journal, Book. Each links to its section. Think Hoshinoya's room selection: atmospheric, not informational.
6. **Newsletter signup** — Minimal. "Stay close." Email field + submit. Cormorant heading, Instrument Sans input. No long explanation.
7. **Footer** — Wordmark, copyright, minimal links (About, Journal, Instagram). Social icon for @auwa.life. Void background.

Journal Index

Structure:

- Page title: "Journal" in Cormorant
- Filter/category tags: Seasons, Craft, Travel, Philosophy (Instrument Sans, subtle)
- Article grid: Kinfolk-style cards, atmospheric photography, varied sizes
- Pagination or infinite scroll (start with pagination — cleaner, more intentional)

Journal Article Page

This is the most important page to get right. It's where people spend time, where SEO value lives, and where the brand voice is most fully expressed.

Structure:

- **Hero image** — Full-width, atmospheric, with gentle parallax
- **Title** — Large Cormorant, centred or left-aligned
- **Meta** — Date, reading time, category. Instrument Sans, small, subtle
- **Body** — Serif body copy (Cormorant Regular or consider a dedicated body serif like Crimson Pro or EB Garamond for long-form readability). Wide column (max ~680px) with generous line-height (1.7-1.8). Pull quotes in Cormorant Light, larger, centred. Photography interspersed — full-width or inset with captions.
- **Author block** — Small, minimal. "Words by Tom Vining" or "Words & illustration by Rieko Vining"
- **Related articles** — 2-3 cards at the bottom
- **Newsletter signup** — Repeated at article end

Typography consideration for body copy: The business plan notes the possibility of using serif for body copy (Kinfolk influence). For long-form journal articles, this is worth testing. Cormorant at body sizes (16-18px) may be too delicate — test EB Garamond or Crimson Pro as a dedicated body serif alongside Cormorant for display. Or use Instrument Sans for body and keep the Kinfolk feel through spacing, sizing, and photography treatment.

App Page (Pre-Launch)

- Atmospheric hero (dark, orb glow or AUWA character illustration)
- One line: "A daily awareness practice. Reveal your kokoro."
- Brief poetic description (3-4 sentences, Cormorant)
- Email capture: "Be the first to know."
- No screenshots, no feature lists, no pricing

Store Page (Pre-Launch)

- Atmospheric hero (craftsman photography from Monolise research trips)
- One line: "Lifetime objects with kokoro."
- Brief description of the philosophy (craft over disposability, every object chosen because a master poured their spirit into making it)
- 2-3 preview images of the kinds of objects that will be available
- Email capture: "Be the first to know."

Book Page (Pre-Launch)

- Atmospheric hero (illustration from AUWA stories)
- One line: "A cosmic being who reveals the kokoro in all things."
- Brief introduction to the four stories
- Illustration samples (2-3 atmospheric images)
- Email capture

About Page

- Tom & Rieko's story (short, in brand voice, with photography)
- The philosophy of Yaoyorozu no Kami (accessible, not academic)
- The origin of AUWA (the name, the decade of development)
- The Eshi + Hanmoto model (brief, charming)
- Photography of Tom and Rieko (atmospheric, not corporate headshots)

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4. Design System

Typography

Display/Headlines: Cormorant Light/Regular (or chosen serif after testing — see brand.md Section 3) **Body copy:** To be tested. Options:

- Instrument Sans (current sans-serif — clean, modern, safe)
- EB Garamond or Crimson Pro (serif body — more Kinfolk, more editorial, needs testing for screen readability)
- Cormorant Regular at 16-18px (unified serif — may be too delicate for long-form)

Functional/UI: Instrument Sans 400/500 **Japanese text:** Noto Sans JP (or Noto Serif JP for editorial contexts)

Colour

The cosmic OKLCH palette from brand.md. Dark-first. Light enters through photography and the glow accent.

- Background: void (oklch 0.08 0.025 250)
- Primary text: cosmic-200 (oklch 0.87 0.012 250)
- Secondary text: cosmic-400 (oklch 0.60 0.018 250)
- Accent: glow (oklch 0.85 0.15 105) — sparingly, for links and hover states

- Photography provides warmth and colour variety

Spacing & Layout

- **Max content width:** 1200px (overall), 680px (article body)
- **Generous whitespace** — the page should breathe. Think Kinfolk, not a news site. Minimum 80px between major sections.
- **Grid:** CSS Grid or Flexbox. Asymmetric article cards (Kinfolk-style varied sizes)
- **Responsive breakpoints:** Mobile-first. 640px (sm), 768px (md), 1024px (lg), 1280px (xl)

Motion

Subtle, ambient, never attention-seeking. Consistent with brand.md Section 9.

- **Page transitions:** Gentle fade (200-300ms)
- **Scroll reveals:** Elements fade in and gently rise (5-10px translate) as they enter viewport. Staggered timing for grid items.
- **Photography:** Subtle parallax on hero images (optional — test performance)
- **Hover states:** Gentle opacity shift on cards, subtle glow on links
- **Implementation:** Framer Motion (already in the stack) or CSS transitions for simpler effects

Photography Treatment

All photography follows brand.md Section 6: muted, warm, slight grain, gentle vignette. Create a consistent look across Tom's Japan catalogue. The Lightroom preset should be applied to all images before upload.

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5. Technical Architecture

Stack

- **Framework:** Next.js 16 (App Router, React Server Components)
- **Styling:** Tailwind CSS 4
- **CMS:** Sanity (headless, structured content, real-time preview, image pipeline with hotspot cropping)
- **Hosting:** Vercel (automatic deployments, edge functions, image optimisation)
- **Email:** Resend (transactional + newsletter)
- **Analytics:** Vercel Analytics or Plausible (privacy-respecting, no cookie banners)
- **Fonts:** Google Fonts via next/font (Cormorant, Instrument Sans, Noto Sans JP)

Sanity Content Model

```
// Journal Article
{
  title: string
  slug: slug
  publishedAt: datetime
```

```
  category: reference → Category
  heroImage: image (with hotspot)
  excerpt: text
  body: portable text (rich text with images, pull quotes, embeds)
  author: reference → Author
  seoTitle: string
  seoDescription: text
  relatedArticles: array of references → Article
}

// Category
{
  title: string  // Seasons, Craft, Travel, Philosophy
  slug: slug
  description: text
}

// Author
{
  name: string
  role: string
  image: image
  bio: text
}

// Page (for App, Store, Book, About — editable)
{
  title: string
  slug: slug
  heroImage: image
  body: portable text
  seoTitle: string
  seoDescription: text
}

// Newsletter Subscriber (or handle via Resend directly)
{
  email: string
  source: string  // which page they signed up from
  subscribedAt: datetime
}
```

Image Pipeline

- Sanity's image CDN handles responsive sizing, format conversion (WebP/AVIF), and cropping
- All images uploaded at 2x resolution minimum (2400px wide for full-width heroes)

- Hotspot cropping set in Sanity Studio for each image (ensures correct focal point across aspect ratios)
- Lazy loading for below-fold images (Next.js Image component handles this)
- Target: 95+ Lighthouse performance score

SEO

- Dynamic meta tags per page (title, description, OG image)
- Structured data (JSON-LD) for articles (Article schema)
- Sitemap auto-generated
- Canonical URLs
- Journal articles are the primary SEO asset — target long-tail keywords around Japanese philosophy, craft, seasonal living, awareness

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6. Build Approach

v0 / Stitch Prompt Ideas

Use v0.dev or Stitch to rapidly scaffold pages, then refine in Claude Code. Prompts should be specific and reference-heavy:

Homepage prompt: "Create a dark-mode editorial homepage inspired by Kinfolk magazine. Serif display typography (Cormorant), sans-serif navigation (Inter or similar). Full-width hero with atmospheric photography and large headline overlay. Below: a brand statement line centred with generous whitespace, then a 3-column asymmetric article card grid (varied card sizes, dark backgrounds, warm photography). Minimal footer with wordmark. Overall feel: Japanese luxury hospitality meets design magazine. Colour: near-black backgrounds (#0f0f14), off-white text (#dddde2), subtle yellow-green accent (#c4cc5a). Tailwind CSS."

Article page prompt: "Create a long-form article page with dark background. Full-width hero image with parallax. Large serif headline (Cormorant) centred below hero. Article body in a narrow column (max 680px) with generous line-height. Pull quotes in larger serif, centred. Full-width photography interspersed. Author block at bottom. Related article cards (2-3) below. Newsletter signup at end. Dark, atmospheric, editorial. Think Cereal magazine online."

Journal index prompt: "Create a magazine-style article index page with dark background. Page title in large serif. Filter row with category tags. Article cards in asymmetric grid — mix of large (spanning 2 columns) and standard cards. Each card: atmospheric image, serif headline, one-line excerpt, category badge. Hover: subtle scale and brightness shift. Kinfolk/Cereal aesthetic. Dark mode."

Build Timeline (Achievable in a Few Days)

Day 1: Scaffold + Homepage

- Set up Next.js 16 + Tailwind 4 + Sanity
- Scaffold homepage layout (v0/Stitch for initial structure, Claude Code for refinement)
- Configure fonts (Cormorant, Instrument Sans, Noto Sans JP)
- Implement colour system (OKLCH custom properties in Tailwind config)
- Homepage: header, hero, brand statement, article grid (with placeholder content), newsletter signup, footer

Day 2: Article Pages + Journal Index

- Journal article page template (the most important page)
- Journal index with category filtering
- Sanity content model for articles, categories, authors
- Sanity Studio configured with preview
- Responsive testing across breakpoints

Day 3: Remaining Pages + Polish

- App, Store, Book pre-launch pages (atmospheric, simple)
- About page
- Newsletter integration (Resend)
- Motion: scroll reveals, hover states, page transitions
- SEO: meta tags, OG images, structured data
- Performance optimisation, Lighthouse audit
- Deploy to Vercel, connect domain

Day 4: Content Population

- Populate initial journal articles (see Section 7)
- Final photography treatment and upload
- Cross-browser testing
- Soft launch

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7. Preparing Initial Articles (The Day-One Content Plan)

The website needs content on day one. An empty journal undermines the editorial positioning. Aim for 8-10 articles prepared and ready to publish at launch — a mix that showcases the four content territories (seasons, craft, travel, philosophy) and gives the site enough density to feel established.

Article Preparation Approach

Tom and Rieko can prepare ~10 articles in a focused day using this workflow:

1. **Select 10 topics** from the list below
2. **Gather photography** from Tom's 15+ year Japan catalogue (already shot, just needs selection and Lightroom treatment)
3. **Write first drafts** — Tom writes in brand voice, 800-1500 words per article. Some can be shorter (500-word seasonal reflections). Use Claude to help draft, then edit for voice and authenticity.
4. **Rieko reviews** for cultural accuracy and adds Japanese terms/context
5. **Apply photography treatment** (Lightroom "AUWA — Atmospheric" preset)
6. **Upload to Sanity** with metadata, hero images, categories, SEO descriptions

Suggested Initial Articles

Seasons (2-3 articles):

- "The Fifth Day" — An introduction to how Japan divides the year into 72 micro-seasons, and what it means to notice the world in five-day increments. Photography: seasonal Japan landscapes.
- "Seimei (清明): The Light Returns" — A seasonal essay tied to the current micro-season at launch. Atmospheric, personal, grounded in a specific place and moment in Japan.

Craft (2-3 articles):

- "The Knife Maker of Seki" — Profile of a craftsman Tom and Rieko met during their Monolise research. The story of a lifetime spent perfecting a single craft. Photography from the workshop visit.
- "Objects with Kokoro" — An essay on the philosophy of choosing lifetime objects over disposable ones. Why a hand-forged knife or a ceramic cup from a master artisan changes your relationship with daily life.
- "What Wabi-Sabi Actually Means" — Reclaiming the concept from Instagram aesthetics. What it means to find beauty in imperfection and impermanence, beyond the interiors trend.

Travel (2-3 articles):

- "Temple Mornings" — An atmospheric essay about the ritual of visiting Japanese temples at dawn. The silence, the light, the practice of being present. Photography: Tom's temple work.
- "The Onsen Lesson" — On the Japanese bathing culture and what it teaches about shared space, vulnerability, and attention. Not a guide — a reflection.

Philosophy (2-3 articles):

- "Everything Has Kokoro" — The foundational essay. An accessible introduction to Yaoyorozu no Kami and why it matters in modern life. The philosophical anchor for the entire journal.
- "Awareness, Not Mindfulness" — Why AUWA uses the word "awareness" instead of "mindfulness." The difference between a Western self-help concept and a Japanese philosophical worldview.
- "The Guest" — On being a respectful visitor to Japan (and to any culture). The awareness that comes from understanding you are in someone else's home. Photography: Japan travel moments.

Content Calendar (Post-Launch)

After the initial 10 articles, publish 1-2 articles per week aligned with the 72 micro-seasons content calendar. Each micro-season (5 days) is an opportunity for a seasonal essay, craftsman profile, or travel piece. This gives the journal a natural rhythm without feeling forced.

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8. Newsletter Strategy

Tool: Resend (already in the tech stack for transactional email)

Signup points:

- Homepage (dedicated section)
- End of every journal article
- App/Store/Book pre-launch pages
- Dedicated /newsletter page

Frequency: Bi-weekly or monthly. Tied to seasonal rhythm. Not a marketing blast — a quiet, beautiful email that feels like receiving a letter. Short, atmospheric, links to new journal articles and seasonal reflections.

Subject line style: Poetic, not clickbait. "Seimei: the light returns" not "5 Japanese philosophy tips you need to read."

Template: Dark background, serif typography, one atmospheric image, 2-3 short text blocks linking to journal articles. Wordmark footer. Mobile-optimised.

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9. Analytics & Performance

- **Vercel Analytics** or **Plausible** — privacy-respecting, no cookie consent banner needed
- **Key metrics:** Page views, unique visitors, time on page (especially journal articles), newsletter signups (conversion rate by page), referral sources
- **Lighthouse target:** 95+ across all categories
- **Core Web Vitals:** LCP < 2.5s, FID < 100ms, CLS < 0.1

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